SĀṂKHYA

THREEFOLD SUFFERING → SYSTEM IDENTITY → THREE INSTRUMENTS → REFLECTION → PRIMORDIAL NATURE → FIVE PROOFS → THREE QUALITIES → CONSCIOUS WITNESS → PLURALITY → TWENTY-FIVE PRINCIPLES → SUBTLE BODY → PRE-EXISTENT EFFECT → REAL TRANSFORMATION → ISOLATION → ŚAṂKARA AND THE ANSWER RAIL

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final synthesis. Each card uses a layout chosen for its own content; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW · ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA · ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • all prior artifacts unchanged

00 STAGE 00 THE CONTROLLING PROBLEM AND THE SHAPE OF THE REMEDY

THREEFOLD SUFFERING · ĀDHYĀTMIKA — FROM WITHIN · ĀDHIBHAUTIKA — FROM BEINGS · ĀDHIDAIVIKA — FROM UNSEEN AGENCIES · PRODUCED RESULTS ARE EXHAUSTIBLE · A MISTAKE IS CORRECTED BY KNOWLEDGE · KNOWLEDGE NEEDS CONTENT · ENUMERATION OF TWENTY-FIVE PRINCIPLES · GRADED, NOT DENOUNCED

suffering strikes from three directions -> ordinary remedies are partial -> ritual results are produced and therefore exhaustible -> a final cure must correct a mistake -> the correction is knowledge -> the knowledge must be enumerated

read forward = why a cosmology is needed · read backward = why the cosmology is soteriological

THE EXHAUSTIVE DIAGNOSIS

- Syllabus item 16, printed verbatim: 'Samkhya; Prakrit; Purusa; Causation; Liberation.' — normalised as Sāṃkhya, prakṛti, puruṣa, causation, liberation.
- Threefold suffering (duḥkha-traya): internal or psychophysical (ādhyātmika); caused by other beings and the material surroundings (ādhibhautika); attributed to cosmic, elemental or unseen agencies (ādhidaivika).

WHY EVERY ORDINARY EXIT FAILS

- Visible remedies — medicine, wealth, protection — operate inside the field of nature, so they redistribute conditions and decay.
- Ritual and scripturally promised results are produced results; what is produced is perishable, therefore repeatable, therefore not final.

WHAT THE FAILURE FORCES

- The required remedy must be non-productive: it cannot manufacture a state, so it must correct a misidentification — and a misidentification is corrected by knowledge, not by action.
- 'Sāṃkhya' is traditionally connected both with enumeration and with discriminative or right knowledge, which is exactly what a system promising release through the knowledge of twenty-five principles requires.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The threefold diagnosis is not decoration: because it is offered as exhaustive, it rules out every remedy that operates inside nature and forces the school to make liberation cognitive rather than active.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya is a soteriology forced to become a cosmology, because a system that promises release by knowledge must first specify, exhaustively, what there is to be known.

01 STAGE 01 SYSTEM IDENTITY AND THE FOUR-RUNG TEXTUAL LADDER

ĪŚVARAKṚṢṆA'S SĀṂKHYAKĀRIKĀ · KAPILA, ĀSURI, PAÑCAŚIKHA · VĀCASPATI MIŚRA'S TATTVAKAUMUDĪ · LATER THEISTIC PHASE · NIRĪŚVARA, NOT ATHEISTIC-BY-PROOF · ORTHODOX SCHOOL, NO CREATOR · YOGA IS A BOUNDED COMPARISON

traditional lineage -> Sāṃkhyakārikā (the classical baseline) -> commentaries -> later, often more theistic phase

THE CLASSICAL DOCTRINAL IDENTITY

- A realist dualism of one unconscious primordial material nature (prakṛti) and many inactive conscious witnesses (puruṣa).
- Causation as the pre-existence of the effect (satkāryavāda) in the specific form of real transformation (pariṇāmavāda); liberation as isolation (kaivalya) through discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna).

HOW TO STATE THE NON-THEISM

- Write non-theistic (nirīśvara) or God-unproved, never simply 'atheistic': primordial nature and conscious witnesses are held sufficient for the explanatory work, which is not the same as proving that no divine being could exist.
- Sāṃkhya is an orthodox (āstika) school that nevertheless requires no creator; 'unorthodox' and 'non-theistic' are different predicates.

THE BOUNDARY WITH YOGA

- Sāṃkhya supplies the dualist metaphysics that classical Yoga substantially shares; Yoga adds the mind-field, the afflictions, the eight-limbed discipline, meditative absorption and God as a special conscious witness.
- Therefore Yoga is a bounded comparison inside a Sāṃkhya answer and never a source of Sāṃkhya doctrine.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Most errors in this topic are permission errors, in which a later theistic reading is used to describe the classical system and silently deletes the non-theism the Kārikā deliberately argues for.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Chronological hygiene is a philosophical commitment here, because the classical identity of the school is fixed by the Sāṃkhyakārikā and cannot be softened by a commentary written centuries later.

02 STAGE 02 THREE INSTRUMENTS OF KNOWLEDGE AND THE SELF-IMPOSED BURDEN

EXACTLY THREE PRAMĀṆAS · PERCEPTION · INFERENCE — THREEFOLD · RELIABLE TESTIMONY · FIVE CANDIDATES REDUCED, NOT REJECTED · SUBTLETY, NOT ABSENCE · SĀMĀNYATO-DṚṢṬA CARRIES THE METAPHYSICS

CANDIDATE INSTRUMENT	SĀṂKHYA REDUCTION	REASON IN ONE LINE
comparison (upamāna)	included in inference or testimony	similarity works because a prior verbal report is applied inferentially to a present case
postulation (arthāpatti)	included in inference	postulation is inference to the best explanatory condition
non-apprehension (anupalabdhi)	perception's failure-conditions	non-perception means the conditions for perceiving are absent or the object is unavailable
inclusion or probability (sambhava)	included in inference	moving from a larger unit to a smaller or probable implication is inferential dependence
traditional report (aitihya)	testimony when reliable	mere tradition has force only once it becomes trustworthy verbal cognition

THE THREE ADMITTED INSTRUMENTS, DEFINED

- Perception (pratyakṣa) is the ascertainment with respect to a presented object (prativiṣayādhyavasāya) through the sense-capacities in contact with it.
- Inference (anumāna) is threefold: pūrvavat from antecedent to effect, clouds to rain; śeṣavat from effect or residue back to cause, one drop to the sea being salty; sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa from a general correlation whose connecting terms are not themselves perceived, the sun in different positions to the sun moving.
- Reliable testimony (āptavacana or śabda) is the word of a non-defective source, pre-eminently Veda or śruti, where the object is not otherwise easily known.

WHY IMPERCEPTIBILITY DOES NOT REFUTE

- The standard causes of non-perception are excessive distance, excessive proximity, defect of the organ, inattention of mind, subtlety (saukṣmya), obstruction by an intervening object, being overpowered by something else, and admixture with like things.
- Root nature's imperceptibility is assigned to subtlety and the witness is likewise beyond the senses (atīndriya); imperceptibility is a fact about the knower's instruments, not a proof of absence.

THE TWO STANDING OBJECTIONS

- Cārvāka: the invariable relation (vyāpti) cannot be secured for a term never perceived, so the inference is speculative. Reply: strict perceptualism cannot explain ordinary causal reasoning either.
- Nyāya: general-correlation inference is legitimate but Sāṃkhya over-extends it, since atoms plus an intelligent God is more economical. Reply: adding God does not explain the material continuity between cause and effect.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — By restricting the instruments of knowledge to three, Sāṃkhya obliges itself to reach two imperceptible ultimates by inference alone, so its proofs are the discharge of a debt rather than an optional flourish.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya's epistemology is not a preface to its metaphysics but a constraint upon it, and every later proof in the system is the payment of a debt the school incurred when it admitted only three instruments of knowledge.

03 STAGE 03 COGNITION, REFLECTION AND THE SYMMETRICAL MISTAKE

INNER INSTRUMENT — THREE FUNCTIONS · BUDDHI DETERMINES · AHAṂKĀRA APPROPRIATES · MANAS COORDINATES · DOORS AND DOORKEEPER · REFLECTION IN TRANSPARENT INTELLECT · FALSE APPROPRIATION IS THE ROOT OF BONDAGE · NOT A MODIFICATION OF THE WITNESS

object -> sense-capacities present -> manas coordinates -> ahaṃkāra appropriates -> buddhi ascertains -> the witness's reflection falls into transparent buddhi -> abhimāna: 'I am the doer, knower, enjoyer' → reflection is a structural fact · appropriation is the error · bondage is the consequence

THE THIRTEENFOLD INSTRUMENT

- The inner instrument (antaḥkaraṇa) has three functions: determinative intellect (buddhi), the I-maker (ahaṃkāra) and the coordinating mind (manas). With five cognitive and five action capacities this forms the thirteenfold instrument (trayodaśa-karaṇa).
- The external faculties function as doors (dvāra) and the inner organ as doorkeeper (dvārin): the senses present, but final ascertainment (adhyavasāya) belongs to the intellect alone.

WHY THE INTELLECT RECEIVES THE REFLECTION

- The intellect is predominantly luminous (sattva) and therefore transparent; transparency is what makes reflection possible, whereas an inertia-heavy organ would obstruct rather than receive.
- The reflection is described as the falling of the witness's shadow into the intellect (puruṣa-chāyā-āpatti / buddhi-pratibimba), and it leaves both relata unchanged.

THE SYMMETRICAL ILLUSION

- Through conjunction or the semblance of conjunction the unconscious internal instrument appears conscious, while the inactive witness appears to be an agent; productive agency belongs to the qualities and evolutes of nature and witnessing belongs to the witness.
- The resulting false appropriation (abhimāna) is the psychological root of bondage, and it must never be described as a real modification of the witness, since a really modified changeless principle could never be released.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Sāṃkhya's most modern-sounding claim is that cognition and consciousness are different things, so a conscious thought is an insentient process illuminated by a light that does no processing.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The intellect processes without being aware and the witness is aware without processing, so what we call a conscious thought is the borrowed light of the second falling on the first.

04 STAGE 04 PRIMORDIAL MATERIAL NATURE: FOUR NAMES AND ONE FAULT-LINE

AVYAKTA PRADHĀNA · ONE, UNCONSCIOUS, UNCREATED, ACTIVE · CONSTITUTED BY THREE QUALITIES · ULTIMATE MATERIAL CAUSE · MATERIAL MEANS UNCONSCIOUS, NOT PHYSICAL · NOT A MIND-BODY DUALISM · A CHANGELESS WITNESS CANNOT BECOME A WORLD

WHAT THE RESERVOIR CONTAINS

- Intellect, the I-maker, the mind and the ten capacities, the five subtle elements and the five gross elements are all evolutes of nature, so 'material' here means unconscious rather than physical.
- The fault-line therefore does not run between mind and body; it runs between everything unconscious, however subtle, and pure consciousness.

WHY A SECOND PRINCIPLE IS FORCED

- The world is marked by plurality, transformation, dependence, purposiveness and structured manifestation, and a school that accepts real effects, real bondage and real liberation needs a real material source.
- Since the witness is changeless and inactive it cannot itself become the world, so an active but unconscious second principle is required.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The economy of a single unconscious productive principle is genuine, but it is purchased by placing intellect and ego inside nature, which is what creates the relation problem the final stages must confront.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya's dualism is habitually misdescribed as mind against matter, when in fact it places intellect, ego and mind firmly inside unconscious nature and divides everything that changes from the one thing that merely watches.

05 STAGE 05 FIVE PROOFS, FIVE JOBS, AND THE ONE-NATURE VERDICT

FIVE INFERENCES FOR NATURE · BHEDĀNĀṂ PARIMĀṆĀT · SAMANVAYĀT · ŚAKTITAḤ PRAVṚTTEŚ CA · KĀRAṆA-KĀRYA-VIBHĀGĀT · AVIBHĀGĀT VAIŚVARŪPYASYA — THE ONE-NATURE PROOF · POWER, NOT PLANNING · 2019 Q8(c) ANSWERED HERE

PROOF	ARGUES FROM	WHAT IT DELIVERS
bhedānāṃ parimāṇāt	the finitude, delimitation and measurability of things	a subtler ground from which limitation emerges
samanvayāt	order and common pattern running through diverse effects	a common material basis for coordinated diversity
śaktitaḥ pravṛtteś ca	operation through a cause possessing the relevant power	a productive power adequate to the full range of manifest effects
kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt	cause and effect as distinguishable stages	an unmanifest causal matrix distinct from the manifest order
avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya	the diversified world forming one interconnected cosmos	the verdict that the root must be ONE

WHY THE FIRST FOUR CANNOT DELIVER UNITY

- Several reservoirs could each be subtler than their products, each display internal pattern, each possess productive power and each differ in stage from their effects; none of the four takes unity as a premise, so none yields unity as a conclusion.
- The bridge sentence the examiner wants: the premise of the fifth proof is the world's undivided interconnectedness, so plurality at the root would falsify that premise rather than merely complicate the conclusion.

TEXTUAL CONTROL ON THE THIRD PROOF

- The standard reading of Sāṃkhyakārikā 15 is śaktitaḥ pravṛtteś ca, not kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ: the argument is from causal power and operation, not from conscious purposive planning.
- The misreading converts a non-theistic argument into a design argument, which would be fatal to a system that denies a creator.

THE HONEST LIMIT

- The verdict holds within Sāṃkhya's own inferential licence; a Nyāya atomist declines it by tracing the world's interconnectedness to coordination among many causes rather than to a single origin.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Learning these as five interchangeable slogans guarantees a wrong answer, because the printed 2019 question asks precisely which one of them constrains the number of material roots.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Four of the proofs establish that there is an unmanifest material root; only the argument from the undivided source of a diversified universe establishes how many there can be.

06 STAGE 06 THE THREE QUALITIES: ONE TRIAD, TWO STATES, TWO MODIFICATIONS

SATTVA — PLEASURE — MANIFESTATION · RAJAS — PAIN — MOVEMENT · TAMAS — DELUSION — CONCEALMENT · NOT THREE SUBSTANCES · EQUILIBRIUM = SĀMYĀVASTHĀ · SARŪPA-PARIṆĀMA · VIRŪPA-PARIṆĀMA · 2021 Q6(b) NEEDS BOTH HALVES

WHAT THE QUALITIES ARE

- They are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies within one nature, occurring together in every evolute in varying proportion.
- Because character, affective tone and evolutionary function are mapped together, a single triad explains physical constitution, mental state and moral temperament at once.

THE TWO MODIFICATIONS

- In equilibrium (sāmyāvasthā) each quality transforms within its own nature — homogeneous modification (sarūpa-pariṇāma) — which keeps nature dynamic while still undifferentiated, so dissolution is not annihilation.
- When equilibrium is disturbed the qualities enter asymmetrical relations and generate differentiated evolutes — heterogeneous modification (virūpa-pariṇāma) — to which actual cosmological evolution belongs.

THE TRIGGER, STATED CAREFULLY

- Disturbance is not mechanical collision. Sāṃkhya speaks only of functional activation in the mere presence of the witness, which is the system's most exposed joint and the exact point Śaṃkara attacks.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The mechanism of every Sāṃkhya causal claim is quality-modification, so the real transformation asserted later in the system is nothing other than the heterogeneous modification described here.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The theory of the three qualities is Sāṃkhya's most economical achievement, because one triad is made to explain physical constitution, affective tone and moral temperament together.

07 STAGE 07 THE CONSCIOUS WITNESS: FIVE PROOFS AS ONE CUMULATIVE INFERENCE

PURE CONSCIOUSNESS, SELF-LUMINOUS · SAṄGHĀTA-PARĀRTHATVĀT · TRIGUṆĀDI-VIPARYAYĀT · ADHIṢṬHĀNĀT — NOT A GOD-PROOF · BHOKTṚ-BHĀVĀT · KAIVALYĀRTHAṂ PRAVṚTTEḤ · CUMULATIVE, NOT ISOLATED · 2022 Q5(a) ASKS FOR THE EVALUATION

everything objective is unconscious, instrumental and presented -> aggregates exist for another -> the knower differs from the known -> coordination needs a presiding witness -> presented states need an experiencer -> striving for release needs a liberable witness -> a non-quality-constituted conscious principle → the form of all five is sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference, from the general structure of objectifiable experience to a witness that is never itself an object

THE FIRST THREE MOVES

- Aggregates exist for another (saṅghāta-parārthatvāt): body, senses, mind and intellect are complexes, and a complex functions instrumentally for a user distinct from it.
- The witness must be other than the qualities (triguṇādi-viparyayāt), because the knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be reducible to the same changing states that are known.
- Coordinated psychophysical life requires a presiding conscious locus (adhiṣṭhānāt) — expressly an inference to a witness of lived order and not a proof of God.

THE LAST TWO MOVES

- Presented pleasure, pain and delusion require an experiencer distinct from them (bhoktṛ-bhāvāt), since unconscious nature can present experience but cannot be the subject for whom experience appears.
- The intelligibility of striving for release presupposes a liberable witness (kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ), because such striving would be unintelligible without a conscious principle distinct from bondage-producing nature.

THE NATURE OF THE WITNESS

- Consciousness is its essence and not a quality it possesses; it is inactive and non-productive, changeless and immutable, entirely beyond the qualities, and a witness, seer and experiencer rather than an agent.
- Two consequences follow immediately: it does not become bound in its own nature, because bondage belongs to misidentification; and it does not produce the world, because all production belongs to nature.

EVALUATING THE PROOFS

- Each proof alone invites a deflationary reply — a Buddhist explains coordination by causal series and ownership by convention — but together they converge on the point that a domain of presentation without a subject-pole is not a domain of presentation at all.
- Their honest limit is that they establish a subject-pole, not yet an eternal, plural and wholly inactive one; those properties come from the account of individuation and from the system's soteriological requirements.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Presenting these as five independent demonstrations weakens the answer, whereas presenting them as one argument in five movements is exactly what the directive to evaluate rewards.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Everything we can point to inside the person is an instrument, and an instrument that is genuinely for no one is not an instrument at all.

08 STAGE 08 PLURALITY, PURPOSIVE NATURE AND THE EMPIRICAL SELF

MANY WITNESSES, NUMERICALLY NOT QUALITATIVELY · SĀṂKHYAKĀRIKĀ 18 GIVES THREE ARGUMENTS · DIFFERENTIAL LIBERATION IS SUPPLEMENTARY · UPĀDHI OBJECTION · ARTHAKRIYĀ OBJECTION · PURUṢĀRTHA WITHOUT INTENTION · JĪVA IS NOT A SEPARATE PRINCIPLE

PURPOSIVE NATURE, FOUR CANONICAL IMAGES

- Milk flowing for the calf shows that unconscious functioning can serve a purposive end; the lame man and the blind man show complementarity, since the witness sees but cannot act while nature acts but cannot see.
- The dancer retires once she has been seen, and the modest woman withdraws on being seen: after discriminative knowledge nature no longer performs binding activity for that witness.

THE EMPIRICAL SELF

- The empirical self (jīva) is not a further principle in the enumeration; it is the witness as empirically appearing through identification with intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.
- Best formulation: the empirical self is the witness as empirically conditioned through the intellect, and the witness is the metaphysical reality behind that appearance.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Source control matters here because attributing a fourth argument to Sāṃkhyakārikā 18 is a checkable error even when the philosophical content of that argument is sound.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya defends many witnesses by an argument from non-transferability — my blindness is not yours and my release would not be yours — yet must individuate entities that by its own account have no features by which to differ.

09 STAGE 09 THE TWENTY-FIVE PRINCIPLES IN EXACT EVOLUTIONARY ORDER

TWENTY-FOUR EVOLUTES PLUS THE WITNESS · MAHAT AND BUDDHI ARE ONE PRINCIPLE · AHAṂKĀRA INDIVIDUATES · LUMINOUS LINE: MIND AND TEN CAPACITIES · INERT LINE: SUBTLE THEN GROSS ELEMENTS · ACTIVE QUALITY ENERGISES, NEVER PRODUCES · ONE / SEVEN / SIXTEEN / ONE · 2024 Q7(a) IS THIS STAGE

prakṛti -> mahat or buddhi -> ahaṃkāra -> [luminous] manas plus five cognitive and five action capacities · [inert] five subtle elements -> five gross elements · [active] energy to both lines

sound to ether · touch to air · form to fire · taste to water · smell to earth

THE THREE TERMS THE 2024 PAPER SEPARATES

- The great one (mahat) and the determinative intellect (buddhi) are the same principle under two names — cosmic and individual — and writing them as two successive stages corrupts both the derivation and the total count.
- The determinative intellect ascertains and discriminates and, being transparent, receives the reflection; the I-maker appropriates as 'I' and 'mine', where false selfhood crystallises; the mind only coordinates.

THE THREE LINES

- From the luminous aspect of the I-maker arise the mind, the five cognitive capacities — hearing, touch, sight, taste and smell — and the five action capacities: speech, grasping, locomotion, excretion and reproduction.
- From the inert aspect arise the five subtle elements and from those the five gross elements; the active quality supplies operative force to both lines and produces no separate set of principles.

BOUNDARY CAUTION

- Advaita's later fivefold grossification (pañcīkaraṇa) must not be imported into a classical Sāṃkhya evolution answer, and the witness is the twenty-fifth principle without ever being an evolute.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The fourfold classification of one evolvent, seven both, sixteen effects and one neither is the fastest control on the whole sequence and prevents the standard miscount of the first evolute.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The list of twenty-five principles is not an inventory but an argument, because deriving intellect, ego, mind and the senses from the same root as the elements makes the knower's equipment as much a part of nature as the known world.

10 STAGE 10 SUBTLE BODY, TRANSMIGRATION AND THE OWNERSHIP PROBLEM

EIGHTEEN CONSTITUENTS · ONE PLUS ONE PLUS ELEVEN PLUS FIVE · EIGHT TENDENCIES OF THE INTELLECT · THE GROSS BODY IS DISCARDED · THE WITNESS NEITHER ACTS NOR MIGRATES · MORAL OWNERSHIP IS ASSERTED, NOT GROUNDED

WHAT THE VEHICLE IS

- The subtle body (liṅga-śarīra or sūkṣma-śarīra) is the continuing psychophysical vehicle between gross embodiments, commonly counted as eighteen constituents: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven capacities including the mind, and the five subtle elements.
- Omitting the mind from the eleven capacities produces seventeen, which is the standard arithmetic slip in this part of the topic.

WHAT CONDITIONS IT

- It is described as primordially arisen within the evolutionary cycle and conditioned by dispositions (bhāva) and the eight broad tendencies of the intellect: merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness.
- At death the gross body produced from parental material falls away while this vehicle carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment.

THE PRESSURE POINT

- The pure conscious witness neither acts nor literally migrates: transmigration belongs to the subtle body and the empirical self-complex operating for a particular witness.
- This preserves inactivity but creates a difficulty, because moral ownership must then be secured through the stable association of one subtle stream with one numerically distinct witness — an association the system asserts rather than grounds.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — This is the weakest joint of the plurality doctrine seen from the ethical side, since the individuality that moral desert requires is exactly the thing the school cannot further explain.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya buys the inactivity of consciousness by relocating rebirth, so what travels between lives is not a self but a disposition-bearing subtle body.

11 STAGE 11 THE PRE-EXISTENT EFFECT: FIVE ARGUMENTS AND FIVE COUNTERS

SATKĀRYAVĀDA · PRODUCTION IS MANIFESTATION · ASADAKARAṆĀT · UPĀDĀNA-GRAHAṆĀT · SARVASAMBHAVĀBHĀVĀT · ŚAKTASYA ŚAKYA-KARAṆĀT · KĀRAṆA-BHĀVĀT · NO MINIATURE TREE IN THE SEED · 2020 Q7(a) IS THIS STAGE

ARGUMENT	STANDING EXAMPLE	COUNTER	SĀṂKHYA REPLY
asadakaraṇāt — a non-entity cannot be produced	no hare's horn; no oil from sand	Nyāya: equivocation between the absolutely and the merely not-yet non-existent	the not-yet effect must still be something determinate, or the operation has no terminus
upādāna-grahaṇāt — a determinate material is taken up	milk for curd; threads for cloth; mango seed not sand	the restriction is explained by causal capacity, not by pre-existence	capacity in the required determinate sense just is the latent presence of that effect
sarvasambhavābhāvāt — everything cannot arise from everything	curd from milk and never from water	restrictions come from the constitution of causes	a constitution capable of producing only one effect is that effect latently present
śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt — the potent produces only the producible	milk has the potency for curd, not for cloth	Nyāya: potency is a relational property of the cause	a merely relational potency cannot explain determinate production
kāraṇa-bhāvāt — the effect has the being of the cause	cloth is threads arranged; ornament and gold	Nyāya: the whole (avayavin) is a new substance with new properties	new properties are new arrangements (saṃsthāna), not new substances from non-being

THE THREE STANDING OBJECTIONS

- If the effect already exists, causal effort is pointless. Reply: production is manifestation (abhivyakti), and effort removes obstruction and supplies conditions rather than creating being.
- The doctrine abolishes the cause-effect distinction. Reply: they differ by state (avasthā), the cause latent and the effect patent. And the doctrine does not imply the world was always as it is now, because only the determinate capacity is latent, never the gross effect.

THE FORMULA TO WRITE

- Latent effect plus material continuity plus real transformation. Never a miniature gross mango tree spatially concealed inside the seed, which is the caricature an opponent refutes in one sentence.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The third argument carries the greatest weight, because non-existence is featureless and a featureless antecedent cannot discriminate between outcomes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The doctrine of the pre-existent effect is best defended as an argument about determinacy, since sheer non-being cannot explain why this cause yields that effect.

12 STAGE 12 REAL TRANSFORMATION AGAINST THE RIVAL CAUSAL THEORIES

PARIṆĀMAVĀDA · VIVARTAVĀDA · ASATKĀRYAVĀDA AND PRĀGABHĀVA · PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA · SHARED PREMISE WITH ADVAITA · DECISIVE DIFFERENCE: REAL OR APPARENT · 2018 Q7(b) IS THIS STAGE

THE ADVAITA REACTION

- An unconscious first principle cannot be the cause described in the Upaniṣads, where the source is spoken of as conscious and knowing.
- An ultimate that really transforms becomes mutable and therefore dependent, so the world's dependence is better explained by superimposition than by evolution.

THE SĀṂKHYA DEFENCE

- The selectivity of production is real — curd comes from milk and not from water — and only a real material continuity explains that restriction, whereas an appearance-theory leaves selectivity unexplained.
- Mutability does not disqualify nature from being ultimate, because nature is by definition the principle whose being is modification; the objection would tell only against a changeless ultimate.
- Treating the world as appearance purchases the immutability of the cause at the cost of the reality of bondage and release, which Sāṃkhya's realism refuses to surrender.

WHERE THE POSITION IS EXPOSED

- An ultimate that genuinely changes invites the Vedāntic question of what sustains its changes, and the Sāṃkhya answer — that nature is by nature modification — is a definition rather than a further explanation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The examiner's favourite trap is the first pair, because Sāṃkhya and Advaita agree that being does not come from non-being and then disagree about everything else.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The dispute with Advaita is not about whether being can come from non-being but about whether an ultimate principle can change without ceasing to be ultimate.

13 STAGE 13 BONDAGE, DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE, ISOLATION AND NON-THEISM

BONDAGE IS AVIVEKA · LIBERATION IS VIVEKA-JÑĀNA · KAIVALYA IS DISENTANGLEMENT · JĪVANMUKTI AND VIDEHAMUKTI · THE POTTER'S WHEEL · NOT MERGER, NOT ANNIHILATION · FIVE NON-THEISTIC ARGUMENTS

the intellect reflects consciousness -> false identification -> the self appears as agent, enjoyer, sufferer and knower -> discrimination becomes steady -> false identification ends -> isolation, which is not identity with Brahman and not the cessation of suffering

THE CIRCUIT

- Bondage is non-discrimination (aviveka) between the witness and nature, generated by reflection and stabilised as false appropriation; it is not a real alteration in the witness.
- Liberation is discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna) that 'I am not nature'; when the distinction becomes steady the false identification ends and the resulting state is isolation (kaivalya), which is disentanglement rather than merger.

TWO STAGES AND THE STRICT FORMULATION

- Liberation while the body still continues by prior momentum is jīvanmukti, on the analogy of a potter's wheel that keeps turning after the impulse ceases; final cessation of embodiment is videhamukti.
- In strict Sāṃkhya the conscious witness is never really bound, liberated or transmigrating: these processes belong to nature and the subtle body, and discriminative knowledge ends a false attribution.

WHY NO GOD IS REQUIRED

- A God acting from desire or motive is neither perfect nor free, and an eternally fulfilled God has no motive to create a painful world.
- If God distributes results under karma, divine independence is limited; if distribution is arbitrary, justice fails. An immutable conscious God cannot be the material source of a changing unconscious world under Sāṃkhya's cause-effect continuity.
- Eternal witnesses and primordial nature already explain consciousness and material evolution without a creator hypothesis — which is why the position is God-unproved rather than a disproof of divinity.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Nothing whatever happens to the witness at liberation, so the school must then explain in what sense there was ever a problem for it, and its answer clarifies the question rather than demonstrating a solution.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: In Sāṃkhya liberation is not a prisoner released but a dancer who leaves the stage once she has been seen, because what ends is nature's performance and not any state of the witness.

14 STAGE 14 THE CONTACT PROBLEM, ŚAṂKARA'S CRITIQUE AND THE ANSWER RAIL

SĀNNIDHYA — MERE PROXIMITY · MAGNET EXPLAINS ACTIVATION · CRYSTAL EXPLAINS APPEARANCE · PRADHĀNA MALLA — THE CHIEF WRESTLER · FOUR OBJECTIONS · UNSTABLE DUALISM · THIRTEEN SOLVED QUESTIONS · GRADED VERDICT

an inactive witness plus an unconscious nature -> what relation is possible? -> mere proximity -> two analogies doing two different jobs -> Śaṃkara defeats each analogy -> the dualism is unstable and needs further explanation

WHY SĀṂKHYA IS THE CHIEF OPPONENT

- It is the most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ultimate explanation, accounting for world, self, bondage, liberation and causation within one coherent system, and is therefore near enough to require detailed refutation.
- Real transformation is the nearest rival to apparent transformation, and both schools appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground — unconscious nature against conscious Brahman — so the contest is direct rather than oblique.

THE FOUR OBJECTIONS

- An unconscious chief principle cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, which is described as conscious and knowing, and tajjña-type knowing-cause texts exclude an insentient nature.
- The contact problem is unresolved: a magnet exerts force, so the analogy either fails or destroys the witness's inactivity, and a crystal explains appearance but never initiation. Teleology, finally, cannot rest on unconscious matter.

THE GRADED VERDICT

- Strong: a rigorously argued non-theistic realism, an economical theory of qualitative variety, a causal thesis that explains determinate production and material continuity, and an early separation of phenomenal consciousness from cognitive processing.
- Weak: the witness-nature relation, unconscious teleology, the individuation of attributeless witnesses, and the obscure beginning of bondage. Contested: early theism, whether isolation is purely negative, and the relation between the Kārikā and Sūtra traditions.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The critique establishes that the dualism needs further explanation and tends either toward monism or toward a third mediating principle; it does not by itself demonstrate that the Advaita account is correct.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Śaṃkara honours Sāṃkhya by attacking it, calling it the chief wrestler precisely because it attempts from an unconscious first principle the very thing Advaita attempts from a conscious one.

E EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH · WHAT PROXIMITY REALLY MEANS · TELEOLOGY WITHOUT AN INTELLIGENT PRINCIPLE · PROVED OR POSTULATED PLURALITY · ONE MOVE, TWO AT MOST · THREE CONTESTED MATTERS

THREE INTERPRETIVE MODULES

- What does proximity amount to? The subtler reading takes it as epistemic or reflective conjunction rather than physical contact; the objection is that a relation changing nothing in either relatum does no work, and the reply appeals to presence-for-the-sake-of-experience.
- Can teleology survive without an intelligent principle? Sāṃkhya treats purposiveness as structural rather than intentional, as milk flows for the calf; the pressure is that a structural description may not be an explanation.
- Is plurality demonstrated or defensively postulated? The school can answer that moral individuality and non-simultaneous liberation become unintelligible on strict one-self models, so the postulate earns its place by what it explains.

WHAT NOT TO OVER-STUDY

- Long textual-strata debates about every principle, specialist disputes on commentarial chronology, detailed later commentarial theism, exhaustive disposition cosmology and full Yoga practice taxonomies.
- Source trail for the modules above: Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhya-kārikā, Vācaspati Miśra's Tattvakaumudī, Gerald James Larson's Classical Sāṃkhya, Chatterjee and Datta, Radhakrishnan and C. D. Sharma.

WHEN THIS WOULD STOP BEING OPTIONAL

- Only if a future question directly asked whether the witness-nature relation is coherent, whether Sāṃkhya's teleology presupposes an intelligent principle, or whether many witnesses are proved rather than postulated.

OPTIONAL STATUS — Everything on this grey card is enrichment and is unnecessary for a competent core answer, because the thirteen routed questions are fully served by the fifteen core stages above.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels